

What Follows From What? Argument Lab

WEEK 1: WHATELY ON LOGIC AND REASONING

Purpose: This lab helps you practice the structure of an argument: the conclusion, the stated reason, the hidden assumption, and the test of whether the conclusion actually follows. Use your marked Whately reading handout while you work. Your answers should focus on reasoning, not just whether you agree with the topic.

Part 1: Model the Four-Step Test

Part 1 Q1: Read the model argument below. Then explain, in your own words, how the four-step test works. Your answer must mention the **conclusion**, the **stated reason**, the **hidden assumption**, and the question of whether the conclusion **follows**.

Model argument: “This rule is popular with most students, so it must be fair.”

- **Conclusion:** The rule must be fair.
- **Stated reason:** Most students like it.
- **Hidden assumption:** Whatever most students like is fair.
- **Test:** The conclusion does not necessarily follow. Popularity and fairness are not the same thing.

Part 1 Q1 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 2: Test Fresh Arguments

Part 2 Q1: Analyze this argument: “The city placed a bronze statue of this man in the town square, so he must have lived nobly.” Identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

Part 2 Q1 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 2 Q2: Analyze this argument: “The first essay uses more difficult words than the second essay, so the first essay must have better reasoning.” Identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

Part 2 Q2 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 2 Q3: Analyze this argument: “Our class has always done the assignment this way, so this way must be the best way to do it.” Identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

Part 2 Q3 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 2 Q4: Analyze this argument: “Every just rule should treat the same action the same way. This rule punishes one student and excuses another student for the same action. Therefore, this rule is not just.” Identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

Part 2 Q4 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 3: Literary Anchor

Part 3 Q1: Choose **one** of the claims below and analyze it with the four-step test. Your answer must identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

- **Macbeth claim:** “The witches predicted Macbeth’s future, so Macbeth is not responsible for what he later chooses.”
- **Caesar claim:** “Caesar may become dangerous later, so Brutus is justified in killing him now.”

Part 3 Q1 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 4: Repair and Create

Part 4 Q1: Choose **one weak argument** from Part 2. Rewrite it so that the conclusion is better supported or more careful. You may change the conclusion, add a missing reason, or narrow the claim.

Part 4 Q1 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 4 Q2: Write one original argument about a school rule, a speaker in *Macbeth* or *Julius Caesar*, a public speech, a sports decision, or a family disagreement. Then analyze your own argument with the four-step test.

Part 4 Q2 ARGUMENT BOX

Part 5: Exit Claim

Part 5 Q1: Complete this claim in one strong paragraph: **Logic helps a reader most when** _____ **because** _____. Use one example from Whately, *Macbeth*, or *Julius Caesar*.

Part 5 Q1 ARGUMENT BOX